

Message in a window

A behind-the-scenes look at how Instant Messengers work and how you can make the most of them



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

Out of sight may no longer mean out of mind! Not if you're the kind who swears by instant messengers (IMs).

The Internet and instant messaging have given a whole new meaning to the term long distance relationships, whether its your favourite aunt settled abroad or your girl friend studying in a different city. Separated by such vast distances, you can still be in close proximity, thanks to all those messages shuttling back and forth at an astounding speed. Adding features every day, instant messaging has encompassed business interests as well. But do you know what makes an IM tick? If you've ever wondered (between sending those smileys

and lovey-dovey hearts!) about the technology that makes this marvellous form of communication possible, then you might not want to put this magazine down until the next few pages.

Anatomy of the chat system

So how does your message reach a friend through the streams of servers spread across a vast geography? The message is sent via copper and fibre connectors across the world at two-thirds the speed of light. In effect, the users find no difference in the delay that occurs due to the transmission of messages across servers. For two people to communicate effectively with each other they need to speak a common

language. Similarly, for two programs to communicate with each other they need to connect through a common convention, called a protocol. The protocol decides the method of communication between the chat client and its server. Most IMs use their own proprietary protocols (that's why a Yahoo! user cannot contact a MSN user, though both may be online).

The user logon process in an IM involves two phases: the authentication phase and the instant messaging phase.

Authentication: When you enter your username and password in the instant messaging client and try to login, the client establishes a temporary connection

